

The Republic of EVIL

How to fight the dubious duality of Pakistan as it becomes the ancestral home of hate

By S. Prasannarajan

Sometimes it takes a certain amount of Gallic flamboyance to tell the truth. Towards the end of his book, *Who Killed Daniel Pearl?*, the French philosopher Bernard-Henri Levy reaches this terrifying conclusion: "I assert that Pakistan is the biggest rogue of all the rogue states today. I assert that what is taking form there, between Islamabad and Karachi, is a black hole compared to which Saddam Hussein's Baghdad was an obsolete dump." Now let us return to two images that bring out the twisted, unequal morality of the post-9/11 war on terror. Elsewhere in the bombed-out Baghdad, the shrunken body of the Baathist dictator dangles from the gallows. In New York, General Pervez Musharraf pops up on *The Daily Show*, enjoying his jasmine tea with a twinkie, to promote his memoirs. That's all the justice you get from the just war.

The war still rages, and the casualty is not confined to Baghdad alone. It has made the warrior-in-chief one of the most unpopular presidents in American history, irrespective of the reality that his country is perhaps the safest place on earth after 9/11 and the world a less dangerous place without a Saddam. Iraq, the main theatre of the war, continues to be ravaged by tribal bloodlust, and Afghanistan, the original provocation, is making it easier for the return of Taliban. And Pakistan? Well, Musharraf is not spending his autumnal isolation in a spider hole somewhere on the outskirts of Islamabad; after a rewarding career in military dictatorship and the business of war on terror, the General is leading a comfortable retired life, probably writing the second instalment of his memoirs. Pakistan is still an ally—in America's war on terror and in terror itself.

It is this dubious duality, perfected during the Musharrafera and carried on by his successors, that is at play in the wake of Mumbai. The ancestry of

terror, once more, is Pakistani. It used to be said that the modern jihad, with its ideological legacy stretching from Syed Qutb to Ayman al-Zawahiri, was born in the torture chambers of Egypt's prisons. Today it is sustained by Pakistan's growing cottage industry of hate. Al Qaeda, Taliban, 9/11 and almost every high profile strike by radical Islam, whether it's the trans-Atlantic airline plot or Mumbai—you can't miss the irrefutable common link of Pakistan. Still, it is not a common anxiety—or fear—that unites the civilised world. We continue to mistake the irrelevant outer, civilian shell for the state that matters. It matters for the singular reason that President Asif Ali Zardari symbolises the limits of civil society in a state whose hardest core is militaristic and Islamic. This sanguineous symmetry of the khaki and the crescent makes the Islamic Republic the most nihilistic state of our times.

India may be its most immediate victim, but the inherent bestiality of Pakistan should not be a worry for India alone. Our victimhood is accentuated by our accumulated mistakes of pussyfooting on—or even romancing—the General and our diplomatic triangulations. Today, the lofty rhetoric of reform-the-society is the most audible suggestion for Pakistan's redemption. It makes no sense when the society itself is trapped between the jackboot of the General and the tyranny of the Book. A

US commission report on terrorism and weapons of mass destruction, *World at Risk*, released after Mumbai, says all the roads of terror "intersect in Pakistan". For once, the axis of evil has an identifiable geopolitical meaning. Only what Robert Kagan in his book *The Return of History* calls a "concert of democracies" can undo the Evil—and let it be jointly conducted by New Delhi and Washington. We are too steeped in a mass delusion to neutralise the weapon of mass destruction called Pakistan. ■

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